Cities, transport and housing

1. Read the article once for meaning. 2. Read it again and look at the **highlighted new words** and the **blue phrases** in context. 3. Study the tables. 4. Use at least 5 new words in speaking or writing this week.

Article: Cities on the move: transport, housing and growth (186 words)

More than half of humanity now lives in cities, and **urbanization** shows no sign of slowing. The pressure is easy to see. Every morning, millions of **commuter** passengers crowd into trains at **rush hour**, while on the roads **congestion** wastes time and fuel. Many cities respond by improving **public transport**: new tram lines, safer **cycle lane** networks and wider **pedestrian** zones. Others introduce a **congestion charge** or raise **road tax** to discourage driving, and encourage **carpooling** instead.

Housing is the second great challenge. **Affordable** homes are scarce, and a young **tenant** may spend half their income on rent, while a **mortgage** is out of reach for many. In poorer regions, rapid growth produces huge **slum** districts, **overcrowded** and short of clean water. Wealthier cities fight **sprawl** by building upwards: a modern **skyscraper** can house thousands of people on a small plot, and a well-planned **suburb** can ease pressure on the centre.

Good planning also means providing **public amenities** such as parks and libraries, and **breathing new life into** neglected districts through **regeneration**. The cities that succeed will be those that **plan ahead** rather than **react to** each crisis.

Useful phrases from the article

PHRASE	MEANING
breathing new life into	renewing
plan ahead	think and prepare early
react to	respond to after

The 20 new words

WORD		MEANING	EXAMPLE
urbanization	n	the growth of cities	*Urbanization puts pressure on housing.*
congestion	n	too much traffic	*Congestion costs the economy millions.*
public transport	n	buses, trains and trams for everyone	*Cheap public transport reduces car use.*
commuter	n	a person who travels to work each day	*Commuters spend hours on trains.*
rush hour	n	the busiest time of the day for traffic	*Rush hour starts at seven.*
affordable	adj	not too expensive	*Affordable housing is urgently needed.*
overcrowded	adj	too full of people	*Overcrowded buses are uncomfortable.*

suburb	n	a residential area outside the city center	*Many families move to the suburbs.*
skyscraper	n	a very tall building	*Skyscrapers save space in big cities.*
pedestrian	n	a person walking	*Pedestrian zones make city centers safer.*
road tax	n	a payment for owning a vehicle	*Higher road tax could reduce traffic.*
congestion charge	n	money paid to drive in a busy area	*The congestion charge cut traffic by a fifth.*
public amenities	n	services such as parks and libraries	*Cities need more public amenities.*
slum	n	a very poor and crowded area	*Millions of people live in slums.*
regeneration	n	rebuilding a poor area	*The regeneration of the docks created jobs.*
carpooling	n	sharing a car with others	*Carpooling reduces the number of cars.*
cycle lane	n	a road path for bikes	*New cycle lanes encourage cycling.*
tenant	n	a person who rents a home	*Tenants pay rent each month.*
mortgage	n	a loan to buy a home	*Many young people cannot get a mortgage.*
sprawl	n	uncontrolled growth of a city	*Urban sprawl swallows farmland.*

Revision: 10 words from last week

WORD		MEANING
globalization	n	the growing connection of world economies and cultures
cultural identity	n	the sense of belonging to a culture
multinational	adj	operating in many countries
tradition	n	a custom passed from generation to generation
heritage	n	history and culture inherited from the past
customs	n	the usual ways of behaving in a society
assimilate	v	to become part of a new culture
stereotype	n	a fixed and often unfair idea about a group
tourism	n	the business of travel for pleasure
mass tourism	n	large numbers of tourists

Practice: fill the gaps

rush hour · public transport · overcrowded · slum · congestion · carpooling · affordable · sprawl

1. _____ starts at seven.
2. Cheap _____ reduces car use.

3. _____ buses are uncomfortable.
4. Millions of people live in _____.
5. _____ costs the economy millions.
6. _____ reduces the number of cars.
7. _____ housing is urgently needed.
8. Urban _____ swallows farmland.

More words on this topic (not in the article: choose the 10 most useful for you)

bus lane (n): a road lane for buses only
bypass (n): a road that avoids a town
car park (n): a place to leave vehicles
city center (n): the middle of a city
commuter belt (n): the area around a city where commuters live
cost of housing (n): how expensive homes are
crowded (adj): full of people
cycle path (n): a path for cyclists
density (n): how closely packed something is
detached house (n): a house not joined to another
district (n): a part of a town
emissions (n): polluting gases from vehicles
flat (n): an apartment
freight (n): goods carried by transport
green space (n): parks and open land
high-rise (adj): having many floors
housing estate (n): a group of homes built together
inner city (n): the central area of a city
light rail (n): a modern electric railway
metropolitan (adj): connected with a large city
neighborhood (n): a local area
noise pollution (n): harmful loud sounds
overpopulation (n): too many people
park and ride (n): leaving a car and taking a bus
pavement (n): a path beside the road
pedestrianized (adj): closed to cars
property (n): buildings and land
residential (adj): used for housing
road safety (n): keeping traffic users safe
traffic jam (n): a long line of slow vehicles

Topic kit: what to know about this topic

Writing Task 2 questions you may meet

1. Traffic congestion is a growing problem in cities. What are the causes and what solutions can you suggest?
2. Some people believe cities should limit private cars. To what extent do you agree or disagree?
3. More people are moving to cities. What are the advantages and disadvantages?
4. Housing is too expensive for young people. What can be done?

Ideas you can use in essays and in speaking

- **For / good:** Better public transport and cycle lanes reduce the number of cars on the road.
- **Against / bad:** Congestion charges may hurt low-income workers who have no alternative.
- **For / good:** Cities offer jobs, services and culture that rural areas lack.
- **Against / bad:** Rapid urban growth creates slums, pollution and overcrowding.
- **For / good:** Building affordable housing and regenerating old districts eases the shortage.
- **Against / bad:** Rent rises and mortgages stay out of reach if wages do not grow.

Speaking

Part 1

- Do you live in a house or an apartment?
- What transport do you use most?
- Do you like your neighborhood?
- Is traffic bad where you live?
- Would you like to live in another city?

Part 3

- How can cities become less crowded?
- Should public transport be free?
- Will people live in big cities in the future?
- Are skyscrapers a good solution to housing problems?

Part 2 cue card. Describe a city you would like to visit. You should say: where it is, what you know about it, what you would do there, and explain why you want to go.

Answers

1. Rush hour (rush hour)
2. public transport (public transport)
3. Overcrowded (overcrowded)
4. slums (slum)
5. Congestion (congestion)
6. Carpooling (carpooling)
7. Affordable (affordable)
8. sprawl (sprawl)